SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #46 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

“Real men don't cry or ask for help.”

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Where it often comes from

Boys hear “Man up” and “Stop crying” from family, coaches, and peers. They learn to hide fear, sadness, and need, and later struggle to ask for help even when they are hurting. Many men carry pain silently for years.

What Scripture teaches

“Jesus wept.” David, a warrior king, wrote, “I am weary from groaning; all night I flood my bed with weeping.” Paul, a hardened apostle, said, “I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me... For when I am weak, then I am strong.” “Two are better than one... if one falls down, his companion can lift him up.” The strongest Man who ever lived wept, asked His friends to stay with Him, and received help carrying His cross. Strength includes honesty and humility.

> *“Jesus wept”* (John 11:35).

Also see

> “I am weary from groaning; all night I flood my bed with weeping and drench my couch with tears” (Psalm 6:6).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong” (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

> “Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!” (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

Common self-statements

- Men do not show weakness.
- I should handle it myself.
- Crying is for the weak.
- Asking for help means I am less of a man.
- I have to be the rock.
- I cannot let anyone see me struggle.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing a man is either strong or weak.
- Mind reading: Assuming others will lose respect.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling vulnerable and concluding it is unsafe.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will be dismissed.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that real men do not cry or ask for help?
- What did Jesus, David, and Paul do?

- What does silence cost me and the people I love?
- Which men do I respect, and are they really emotionless?
- Who could I trust with something real?
- What is one small step I could take?

Truth summary

> Strength includes honesty. Jesus wept, David wept, and Paul embraced weakness. I can feel, speak, and ask for help, and that makes me a better husband, father, friend, and follower of Christ.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Weakness
- Pride
- Humility
- Friendship
- Depression, Symptoms of

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Real men don't cry or ask for help"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Real men don't cry or ask for help." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me this?
- ☐ What did Jesus do?
- ☐ What does silence cost?
- ☐ Whom do I respect?
- ☐ Whom can I trust?
- ☐ What is my next step?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus wept.
- ☐ David poured out his tears to God.
- ☐ When I am weak, then I am strong.
- ☐ Two are better than one.
- ☐ Asking is wise.
- ☐ Honesty builds trust.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 11:35
  "Jesus wept."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9–10
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."
- ☐ Ecclesiastes 4:9–10
  "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Strong enough to ask: Each week, note one time you named a feeling or asked for help.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 11:35 becomes: "Tom can write: "Jesus wept, and I can be honest too.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Weakness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the rule. Write who taught you and what they said.
- [ ] Find a trusted man. Choose a friend or mentor.
- [ ] Say one real thing. Share a feeling or need.
- [ ] Read Psalm 6. Notice David's honesty.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Real men don't cry or ask for help": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Strong enough to ask
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Real men don't cry or ask for help.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I learned to hide what I feel. Teach me the strength of honesty and the humility to ask for help. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.